



World Cup
2010

Cover Story

The Cup *that* CHEERS

Half a kilo of ball and half the world watching. The World Cup has come to the high places of South Africa and 32 teams will go for goals for the greatest prize in world sports today. Fasten your seatbelts.

By Sharda Ugra

How do you explain a nation whose team is participating in the football World Cup after 44 years but whose people will not see live matches on tv? Who have hired supporters from China because most of their countrymen can neither afford nor may be allowed to travel. Who are separated from their first opponent in the 2010 World Cup by thousands of miles in geography, more than 100 spots in the rankings and a million light years in football heritage.

North Korea versus Brazil, June 20, Johannesburg. It is all inexplicable, illogical but it will happen. It came from a draw watched by presidents, bishops, athletes and movie stars last December, but could have actually been

pulled from the pocket of the most wicked of soccer gods. Yet, this is why the World Cup football is the most riveting of sporting events. For a month it has us witness the dazzling gifts of athleticism and creativity as well as the ambition and ache of nations.

So when the most mysterious team in this year's competition takes on the men whose shirts and memories are shot with gold, their 90 minutes will show us the World Cup in its entire scale. Soccer's glamorous giants versus some of their most humble opponents, five-time champions against the lowest-ranked team to ever have made the Cup final after two years, four months and 16